

Computers System Pvt Ltd, informs that their company is looking for cross-technology expertise from database management to embedded systems, and from mainframe to client-server applications.

There are other trends as well. According to the Manager-HR, I-flex Solutions, Mumbai, which provides IT solutions to the financial sector, the shift is also towards Unix, C and C++. Mainframe skills are back in demand: financial and healthcare institutions invest significantly in data recovery management. Another emerging area is data security, which has the potential to grow at a rate of 14 per cent annually by 2005, according to Nasscom's estimates.

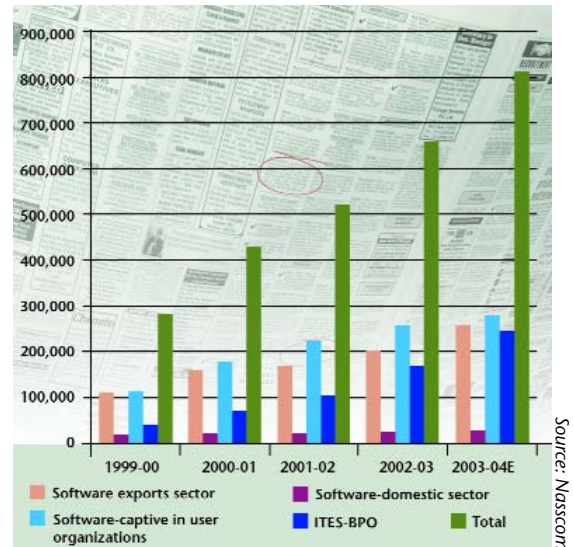
Does all this mean IT companies will only recruit engineers?

Primarily, yes. However, non-engineering graduates can and do look for IT jobs. Top IT companies are hiring MCAs (Master of Computer Applications) and

MCMs (Master of Computer Management). As Ambarish Deshpande, Assistant Vice President-Marketing, of Symantec India, assures, "Being an MBA has in no way been detrimental to my job of selling security solutions to companies." Most IT companies have realised the importance of a strong sales and technical support team, and so non-engineering back-grounders, too, can aspire to be in the IT world—using marketing skills, of course.

ITES: Service with a smile

Last year, the Indian ITES-BPO industry grew 54 per cent, according to Nasscom. What began as mere outsourcing of customer service mostly from the US, is now becoming a niche—



finance, computing equipment, etc.

Firms such as eServe—a part of Citigroup—and Intelenet (a joint venture of

LOOK AT THE WORK PROFILE, NOT MERELY SHORT SALARY SPIKES

Focus Consultants is one of India's top IT placement consultants.

Vipul Varma, CEO, talks about trends in IT recruiting in India

Digit: What are the reasons for the steady increase in the field of IT and ITES?

Vipul Varma (VV): The year 2000 was a period of recession for the IT industry, with the economy slump and the dotcom bust. Post 2002, many MNCs have set up their delivery and offshore centres around the world, India being one of the beneficiaries. This has resulted in more offshore projects and support activities.

Digit: Can you highlight the major trends in IT recruitment over the last couple of years?

VV: There is a great demand for technically qualified personnel with a work experience of two to five years. One sees a shift to package software skillsets such as ERP, Siebel CRM solutions, Oracle APS, Baan ERP, etc. Previously, there was a lot of demand for the vanilla skills of mainframes and client/server, but now, Web-based application skills such as .Net and Java/J2EE face a supply constraint. Newer technologies demand more and more professional skills. Also, IT infrastructure and security are newer areas, which would see more recruitment in the coming years.

Digit: How have placement consultants influenced the IT recruitment process?

VV: Consultants save the company the



VIPUL VARMA,
CEO, Focus Consultants

trouble of scanning through hundreds of résumés; a pre-screening is done by the consultants in terms of finding the relevant résumés, and the candidates are pre-screened too. So with a consultant, the shortlisting to final offers is high, unlike job Web sites.

Many consultants offer third-party validation to a candidate vis-à-vis a company's advertisements that are often publicity vehicles. Today, consultants counsel the candidates, and also advise the company on matters of rational salary structure.

Digit: Ten years in the placement industry, and you must have seen innumerable

résumés; what are the most common errors?

VV: From an employer's point of view, a résumé is the first introduction to an applicant's personality. An ideal résumé should not be more than three pages. The common errors that occur are:

- No one ever writes a summary, when the fact is that a summary gives an employer a fair idea of what the candidate is like.
- Applicants tend to describe projects more than their contribution to it.
- They hide uncomfortable truths like pink slips.

■ An applicant should, by the design of his résumé, be able to drive the interview towards his strengths.

Digit: What kinds of pointers would you give Digit Readers aspiring to make it big in IT?

- VV:** ■ Build a career, not a job.
- IT is a knowledge-based industry, so get into continuous learning.
- Develop good interaction skills. Employers also look at Emotional Quotient.
- When joining a company, look at the work profile, not merely short salary spikes.